- Maintaining a balanced diet and regular exercise is important for school-aged children. These children are required to eat a variety of foods from each food group to ensure optimal intake of all vitamins and minerals.
- At the same time, they may face new challenges regarding food choices and habits. Decisions about what to eat are partly determined by what is provided in school, at home, the influences from friends at school, and the media, especially television.
- Poor nutrition compromises both the quality of life of school-aged children and also their potential to benefit from education.
- Adequate nutrition of school aged children will also ensure that they grow to their full potential, and provide the stepping stones to a healthy life.
- Deficiency of essential fatty acids may have a negative impact on school performance.
- Bone density suffers when calcium needs are not met during childhood years
- Milk and dairy products and some dark green, leafy vegetables are good sources of calcium.
- Children need iron because of rapidly expanding blood volume during growth. Meat, fish, poultry, green leafy vegetables and millets are the best sources of dietary iron.
- A variety of fruits and vegetables of different colours should be added in the child's food.
- Dark green leafy vegetables, yellow, orange coloured vegetables and fruits (such as carrots, papaya, mangoes) are good sources of Vitamin A.
- Children get most of their Vitamin D from sunlight and a small amount from some food items like fish oils, fatty fish, mushrooms, cheese and egg yolks.
- Snacks may contribute up to a significant proportion of total daily energy and nutrient needs of the school child.
- Obesity, underweight, constipation, dental caries and anaemia are some of the nutritional problems during the school going period.
- Anaemia in school-aged children may result in deleterious effects including lower school achievement due to impaired cognitive development, poor attention rate and general fatigue.
- Packed lunches have become a necessity for school going children as schools are either away or the lunch period is too short for the children to go home and have food.
- The school lunch should meet one third daily requirement in calories, protein and other nutrients of the child, to boost concentration and energy for the rest of the school day
- A nutritious breakfast is a central feature of a child's diet that supports healthy growth and development. Breakfast is the first meal of the day.
- A healthy breakfast refuels the body and replenishes the blood sugar (glucose), giving the energy necessary to start a new day.
- According to WHO, individuals between 10 and 19 years are considered as adolescents. The period of transition from childhood to adulthood is called adolescence with accelerated physical growth
- The metabolic demands of growth and energy expenditure during adolescence

UNIT-3_Nutrition Children Lesson.3.indd 65 25-02-2019 15:26:21